

Anti-Harassment Policy

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1. Purpose

Northwind Technologies is committed to a workplace free from harassment, discrimination, and retaliation. This policy describes prohibited conduct, reporting procedures, and Northwind's response to reports of harassment. It applies to all employees, contractors, interns, vendors, customers, and visitors interacting with Northwind personnel.

2. Prohibited Conduct

Northwind prohibits harassment based on any legally protected characteristic, including race, color, national origin, religion, sex, sexual orientation, gender identity or expression, age (40 or older), disability, pregnancy, veteran status, genetic information, marital status, or any other characteristic protected by applicable law.

Harassment may take many forms, including:

- Verbal: slurs, epithets, derogatory comments, jokes, threats
- Physical: assault, unwanted touching, blocking movement, intimidating gestures
- Visual: offensive images, gestures, graffiti, written materials
- Electronic: harassing emails, chat messages, social media posts, video calls
- Sexual: unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, sexually explicit comments or imagery

Conduct does not have to be intentional or directed at a specific person to constitute harassment. A single severe incident, or a pattern of less severe conduct, may both violate this policy.

3. Sexual Harassment

Sexual harassment includes any of the following:

- Unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, or other verbal or physical conduct of a sexual nature
- Conditioning employment benefits (hiring, promotion, evaluation) on sexual conduct
- Conduct of a sexual nature that creates an intimidating, hostile, or offensive work environment

Romantic or sexual relationships between employees are not prohibited, but relationships between an employee and someone in their reporting chain must be disclosed to People Operations so that appropriate steps can be taken to remove conflicts of interest.

4. Retaliation

Northwind strictly prohibits retaliation against any person who, in good faith:

- Reports harassment or discrimination
- Participates in or cooperates with an investigation
- Opposes practices believed to violate this policy
- Requests a workplace accommodation

Retaliation may include termination, demotion, schedule changes, exclusion from meetings, negative reviews, or any other adverse action. Retaliation is itself grounds for disciplinary action up to and including termination.

5. Reporting

Employees who experience or witness harassment, discrimination, or retaliation are strongly encouraged to report it promptly. Reports may be made through any of the following channels:

- Direct manager (if not the subject of the report)
- Skip-level manager
- People Operations: people-ops@northwind.example or 1-800-NW-PEOPLE
- Legal: legal@northwind.example
- Ethics Hotline: 1-800-NW-ETHICS (anonymous, 24/7)
- Online reporting portal: ethics.northwind.example

Reports may be made anonymously through the Ethics Hotline or online portal, though Northwind's ability to investigate may be limited without contact information.

6. Investigation Process

All reports of harassment will be promptly and thoroughly investigated. The investigation will be conducted by a trained People Operations investigator or, in complex cases, by outside counsel. Typical investigation steps include:

- Interview with the reporting party (the complainant)
- Interview with the subject of the report (the respondent)
- Interviews with witnesses identified by either party
- Review of relevant documents, messages, and records
- Documented findings of fact and a written determination

Investigations are completed as quickly as possible, generally within 30 days of the initial report. The complainant and respondent are kept informed of the investigation's progress and outcome to the extent possible while maintaining appropriate confidentiality.

7. Confidentiality

Northwind treats harassment reports with the utmost discretion. Information is shared only with those who need to know to conduct the investigation, make decisions, and implement remedial measures. Northwind cannot guarantee absolute confidentiality but commits to limiting disclosure to the extent possible.

8. Outcomes and Remedial Action

If an investigation concludes that harassment occurred, Northwind will take prompt and effective remedial action. Possible outcomes include:

- Verbal or written warning
- Mandatory training or coaching
- Reassignment, demotion, or change in reporting structure
- Suspension without pay
- Termination of employment
- For contractors or vendors: termination of the engagement

Even where an investigation does not establish a policy violation, Northwind may take steps to prevent future concerns, such as additional training, schedule adjustments, or revised communication norms.

9. False Reports

Reports made in bad faith — meaning, with knowledge that they are false or with reckless disregard for the truth — may themselves be subject to disciplinary action. However, a good-faith report that is not substantiated will not result in discipline. The distinction is between honest reports of perceived problems and deliberate fabrication.

10. Training

All employees complete anti-harassment training within 30 days of hire and annually thereafter. Managers and supervisors receive additional training on recognizing, responding to, and preventing harassment. Training completion is tracked in the Northwind compliance system, and failure to complete required training may result in disciplinary action.

11. Support Resources

Northwind provides confidential support resources for employees affected by harassment:

- Employee Assistance Program (EAP): 24/7 counseling and support, 1-800-NW-EAP
- Medical and mental health benefits through Northwind's health plan
- Paid time off for related medical or legal appointments (does not count against PTO)

12. Records

Records of harassment reports, investigations, and outcomes are retained securely by People Operations for at least 7 years from the date of the report, and longer where required by applicable law.